



Windows 7 on USB drives?

While there is no official word yet, there are rumours flying around that Microsoft will offer Windows 7 on USB drives, as many netbooks do not have optical drives

USB 3.0 starts shipping

LucidPort has started shipping ports for the new standard, USB 3.0, called USB300. The port offers ten times the speed of USB 2.0

Flash Drive Test



Flash memory is a market of plenty, and that's where the problems begin...

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I'm usually out looking at prices for a wide range of technology products, and often come across some great deals that I inform you of in my regular column. Recently, I started getting a lot of mails asking me about buying advice for flash memory. Now this is a very, very important segment. Think about it – although we've tested everything from a Rs. 2,000 phone to a TV that costs Rs. 20 lakh – with quite a few tasty graphic cards, PMPs and speaker sets thrown in, it's categories like this that most of you will buy on a more regular basis. The real CD killer, flash memory is the reason we can all carry about GBs of data in our pockets, or in our phones. With megapixel ratings on

cameras climbing constantly, even those with entry-level shooters need to have large capacity flash memory.

Size isn't everything

My apologies for the cliché, but with all types of data storage mediums, this is quite a valid statement. As you know, even entry-level phones are capable of audio and video playback, and the amount of data we want to carry with us is measured in GBs now, instead of MBs. How well your phone performs is dependent on the speed of the flash memory it's reading from and writing to. Even when it comes to the "thumb drive" segment, most of us expect to pull out our drives, plug it into a friend's box, and copy his entire music collection – quite illegal, but that didn't stop you before, did it? Like most crimes, you want this little

caper to be done with quickly, and don't want to be sitting around waiting an hour for all this to copy, do you?

Of course, size isn't nothing either, because at the end of the day, we all want to carry our precious data, and are willing to compromise on speeds. So why not just buy a USB hard drive? Because not all of us want that much storage, or are willing to carry around bulky (by comparison) hard drives. Flash drives are truly portable, and memory cards just fit into devices that you're already carrying.

We've never tested memory cards before at Digit, so this was a really interesting few days for us. We also decided only to test high capacity flash drives, because the falling prices have made eight GB (and larger) drives very affordable, and rather enticing as well.

Flash drives

Setting the cutoff at 8 GB and above, I ended up with 10 high-capacity flash drives in my hands. Although there was a variety in prices of these drives (Rs. 1,100 to Rs. 15,591), I decided to stick to my original plan and categorise them according to size, and not price. This is because when it comes to portable flash memory, your storage requirements dictate what you go out and look for. You're more likely to decide that you want or need an 8 GB drive, and then look at all the options you have. Of course some will still set a budget, and then get the most storage they can, even buying unbranded Chinese drives because they're cheap. This article is not for those people however, because any self-respecting Digit reader knows the value of performance, quality and